# INDEPENDENT, ALTERNATIVE, AND COMMUNITY MEDIA AN OPEN READER

Edited and with an introduction by
David W. Park & Meghan Grosse

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# Independent, Alternative, and Community Media: An Open Reader

**Edited by David W. Park & Meghan Grosse**

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# *Contents*

*Introduction: The Promise and Vulnerability of Independent, Alternative, and Community Media*
David W. Park and Meghan Grosse . . . . . xvii

PART 1: CONCEPTUALIZING INDEPENDENT, ALTERNATIVE, AND COMMUNITY MEDIA

*There is No Alternative: The Critical Potential of Alternative Media in the Face of Neoliberalism*
Linus Andersson . . . . . 1

*Uncommunicative Partners: Social Movement Media Analysis and Radcial Educators*
John D. H. Downing . . . . . 20

*Communication and Struggles for Alternatives*
Christian Fuchs . . . . . 29

*What We Talk About When We Talk About "Media Independence"*
Karl Karpinnen and Hallvard Moe . . . . . 43

*The Unbearable Lightness of Being Alternative: Idealism-Realism and Purism-Pragmatism in Greek Alternative Media*
Dimitra L. Milioni and Pantelis Vatikiotis. . . . . 59

PART 2: HISTORY, MEMORY, AND ARCHIVES

*Hand-Made Memories: Remediating Cultural Memory in DIY Feminist Networks*
Red Chidgey . . . . . 83

*Being a Child of the Mines: Youth Magazines and Comics in the Copperbelt*
Enid Guene . . . . . 93

*Social Participation in Indonesian Media and Art: Echoes from the Past, Visions for the Future*
Edwin Jurriëns . . . . . 112

*Learning from the History of Alternative Communciation Networks*
Félix Tréguer, Dominique Trudel, and Mélanie Dulong de Rosnay . . . . . 134

*A Brief History of CCLM/CLMP*
Pauline Uchmanowicz . . . . . 152

*Promising Prospects, and the Hurdles Along the Way: Sharing and Archiving Community Media Content Online*
Joost van Beek . . . . . 163

PART 3: POLICY, REGULATIONS, AND GOVERNMENT INTERVENTION

*Media at the Margins: Policy and Practice in American, Canadian, and British Community Television*
Christopher Ali . . . . . 173

*News by Any Other Name: Community Radio Journalism in India*
Bridget Backhaus . . . . . 192

*'In the Waiting Room': Digitsation and Post-Neoliberalism in Buenos Aires*
Geoff Baker . . . . . 208

*From Revolution to Reform: Recommendations for Spectrum Policy in Transitional Tunisia*
Moez Chakchouk, Danielle Kehl, Jochai Ben-Avie, and Kate Coyer . . . . . 244

*From Media Niche to Policy Spotlight: Mapping Community-Media Policy Change in Latin America*
Arne Hintz . . . . . 269

*Community Radio Contradictions in Canada: Learning from Volunteers Impacted by Commercialising Policies and Practices*
Gretchen King and Omme-Salma Rahemtullah . . . . . 282

PART 4: PRODUCTION AND DISTRIBUTION

*Podcasting About Yourself and Challenging Norms: An Investigation of Independent Women Podcasters in Denmark*
Freja Sørine Adler Berg . . . . . 305

*The Business of DIY: Characteristics, Motives and Ideologies of Microindependent Record Labels*
Robin den Drijver and Erik Hitters . . . . . 323

*Intervention for Inclusivity: Gender Politics and Indie Game Development*
Stephanie Fisher and Alison Harvey . . . . . 342

*From Art House to Your House: The Distribution of Quality Cinema on Home Video*
Daniel Herbert . . . . . 358

*SoundCloud and Bandcamp as Alternative Music Platforms*
David Hesmondhalgh, Ellis Jones, and Andreas Rauh . . . . . 373

*Indie or Mainstream? Tensions and Nuances between the Alternative and the Mainstrean in Indie Games*
Ólivier Pérez-Latorre . . . . . 393

*Making Media Together: Experiences of Aboriginal Participation within Co-Creative Remote Media Production Teams*
Laura McDowell. . . . . 408

*Participatory Film Production as Media Practice*
Antoni Roig Telo . . . . . 427

PART 5: LABOR, FUNDING, AND PROMOTION

*Indie Cinema and Short Film Assemblage*
Thomas Barker . . . . . 449

*Independent Canadian Music in the Streaming Age*
Andrew deWaard, Brian Fauteux, and Brianne Selman . . . . . 459

*Crowdfunding for Independent Print Media: E-Commerce, Marketing, and Business Development*
Peter Konhäusner, Marius Thielmann, Veronica Thielmann, Veronica Câmpian, and Dan-Cristian Dabija . . . . . 489

*'Let's Keep Music Special. F—Spotify': On-Demand Streaming and the Controversy over Artist Royalties*
Lee Marshall . . . . . 513

*DIY or Die? A Typology of DIY Careers in the Portuguese Independent Music Scenes*
Ana Oliveira . . . . . 528

*The Political Economy of Financially Successful Independent Hip-Hop Artists*
Geoff Ostrove. . . . . 544

*Autonomy, Integration, and the Work of Cultural Intermediation in Indie Games*
Matthew E. Perks, Felan Parker, Jennifer R. Whitson, Gabrielle Lavenir, Ceyda Yolgörmez, Pierson Browne, and Brian Schram . . . . . 564

*Seeking Deep Relations in a Precarious Industry: Addressing Mental Health through Independent Videogame Development*
Paulo Ruffino . . . . . 584

PART 6: MESSAGES, NARRATIVES, AND REPRESENTATIONS

*What I Know Now: Radio as a Means of Empowerment for Women of Lived Prison Experience*
Heather Anderson and Charlotte Bedford. . . . . 603

*Are You Okay? Mental Health Narratives in Art Zines from the Zineopolis Collection*
Jackie Batey . . . . . 619

*"I Want to Tell You about My Life Now": The Voice of Palestinian Refugees in Frontiers of Dreams and Fears*
Catherine Burwell . . . . . 633

*American Realities on Public Television: Analysis of the Independent Television Service's Documentaries, 2007-2016*
Caty Borum Chattoo, Patricia Aufderheide, Michele Alexander, and Chandler Green . . . . . 647

*Against Hollywood: American Independent Film as a Critical Cultural Movement*
Sherry B. Ortner. . . . . 670

*Alternative Media, Self-Representation and Arab-American Women*
Kenza Oumlil . . . . . 689

PART 7: AUDIENCES: PARTICIPATION, ENGAGEMENT, AND ACCESS

*Conventions, Computers, and Collective Action (1991-2007)*
Francesca Coppa . . . . . 709

*Coming Out as Popular Media Practice: The Politics of Queer Youth Coming Out on YouTube*
Sander De Ridder and Frederik Dhaenens . . . . . 743

*Public Value and Participation of Civil Society—A Case for Public Service or Community Media?*
Manuela Grünangerl, Josef Trappel, and Corinna Wenzel. . . . . 759

*Moments of Danger: The Struggle for Community-based Public Radio in Baltimore*
Jason Loviglio. . . . . 784

*Making Media Public: On Revolutionary Street Screenings in Egypt*
Nina Grønlykke Mollerup and Sherief Gaber . . . . . 800

*The Death of Indie Hip-Hop?:The Blurry Lines Between the Majors and Independent Hip-Hop*
Christopher Vito . . . . . 815

PART 8: JOURNALISM AND THE PUBLIC

*Podcasting as Public Media: The Future of U.S. News, Public Affairs, and Educational Podcasts*
Patricia Aufderheide, David Lieberman, Atika Alkhallouf, and Jiji Majiri Ugboma . . . . . 841

*The Future of Public Service Media and the Internet*
Alessandra D'Arma, Christian Fuchs, Minna Horowitz, and Klaus Unterberger . . . . . 861

*Community Radio and Peace-building in Kenya*
Jessica Gustafsson . . . . . 871

*Intersectionality in Autonomous Journalism Practices*
Sandra Jeppesen and Media Action Research Group . . . . . 887

*Amplifying Counter-Public Spheres on Social Media: News Sharing of Alternative Versus Traditional Media After the 2019 Chilean Uprising*
Juan Pablo Luna, Sergio Toro, and Sebastián Valenzuelap . . . . . 906

*Iranian Internet Cinema, a Cinema of Embodied Protest: Imperfect, Amateur, Small, Unauthorized, Global*
Hamid Naficy . . . . . 926

*Media Representations of Burundi's 2020 Elections in Belgium and Burundi*
Caroline Williamson Sinalo . . . . . 941

*Digital Amplification of Fringe Voices: Alternative Media and Street Politics in Hong Kong*
Yidong Wang . . . . . 959

PART 9: COMMUNITY AND LOCALISM

*Not Just Surviving but Thriving: Practices That Sustain a New Generation of Latin American Community Media Makers*
Diana Coryat . . . . . 983

*Community Media Makers and the Mediation of Difference: Claiming Citizenship and Belongingness*
Lola de Koning, Elaine Nolten, and Koen Leurs . . . . . 999

*Failties at the Borders: Stalled Activist Media Projects in East Africa*
Christina Dunbar-Hester . . . . . 1015

*Wireless Mesh Networks as Community Hubs: Analysis of Small-Scale Wireless Mesh Networks and Community-Centered Technology Training*
Jamie Alexander Greig . . . . . 1035

*'Neither Silent Nor Invisible': Anti-poverty Communication in the San Francisco Bay Area*
Dorothy Kidd and Bernadette Barker-Plummer . . . . . 1063

*Core Dimensions of Community Radio in Action: The Case of Ghana*
Lawrence Naaikuur and Africanus L. Diedong . . . . . 1077

*Communicative Sovereignty in Latin America: The Case of Radio Mundo Real*
Katherine Reilly . . . . . 1096

*Combatting Cultural 'Nerve Gas': Maintaining Traditional Media and Culture through Local Media Production in Australia, Canada and Mexico*
Ian Watson . . . . . 1115

PART 10: NETWORKS AND SOCIAL MEDIA

*Activist Networks*
Joshua D. Atkinson. . . . . 1133

*Why Diverse Zines Matter: A Case Study of the People of Color Zines Project*
Melanie Ramdarshan Bold . . . . . 1157

*FCJ-193 Harbouring Dissent: Greek Independent and Social Media and the Antifascist Movement*
Sky Croeser and Tim Highfield . . . . . 1172

*The Case for Alternative Social Media*
Robert W. Gehl . . . . . 1189

*The Opium of the Paquete: State Censorship, Private Self-Censorship, and the Content-Distribution Strategies of Cuba's Emergent, Independent Digital-Media Start-Ups*
Ted A. Henken. . . . . 1209

*Bridging the Open Web and APIs: Alternative Social Media Alongside the Corporate Web*
Jack Jamieson, Naomi Yamashita, and Rhonda McEwen . . . . . 1233

*Building Wi-Fi Networks for Communities: Three Canadian Cases*
Catherine Middleton and Barbara Crow . . . . . 1254

PART 11: ACTIVISM AND RESISTANCE

*Punks' Jungle: São Paulo*
Rodrigo Lopes de Barros . . . . . 1281

*The Lumad Struggle for Social and Environmental Justice: Alternative Media in a Socio-Environmental Movement in the Philippines*
Belinda F. Espiritu . . . . . 1315

*Indymedia and the Long Story of Rebellion Against Neoliberal Capitalsim*
Natalie Fenton . . . . . 1332

*Bearing Witness to Authoritarianism and Commoning through Video Activism and Political Film-Making after the Gezi Protests*
Özge Özdüzen . . . . . 1339

*Alternative Media in Latin American Grassroots Integration: Building Networks and New Agendas*
Daniela Parra . . . . . 1355

*Feminist Media as Alternative Media? Theorising Feminist Media from the Perspective of Alternative Media Studies*
Jenny Gunnarsson Payne . . . . . 1374

*Media Activism from Above and Below: Lessons From the 1940s American Reform Movement*
Victor Pickard. . . . . 1390

*Queer Blogs and Digital Archives: A Tactical Shift Towards Queer Utopia in Bangladesh*
Mohammed Mizanur Rashid . . . . . 1405

CHAPTER 51

# Iranian Internet Cinema, a Cinema of Embodied Protest: Imperfect, Amateur, Small, Unauthorized, Global

Hamid Naficy

In *Media and Mapping Practices in the Middle East and North Africa: Producing Space,* edited by Alena Strohmaier and Angela Krewani, 119–38. Amsterdam University Press, 2017.

*Abstract*

This chapter examines the emergence of what I call 'internet cinema' by focusing on Iran in the late 2000s, particularly since the 2009 disputed re-election of Mahmoud Ahmadinejad as president, which unleashed the opposition Green Movement undergirded by this cinema. Iran provides an example of the use of the new internet-driven digital global media in support of democratic ideals that, soon after the Green Movement, rocked many authoritarian regimes of the Middle East and North Africa.

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*Keywords*

Internet cinema, Iran, Green Movement, amateur

## *The Emergence of a Citizen's Medium*

With the success of the Iranian Revolution in 1979, the Islamic Republic took over the broadcast media and placed it under direct control of the 'supreme leader'. Having gotten rid of one authoritarian regime with a monopolistic state-run broadcast media under the Shah, Iranians did not take this lying down. Throughout the 1980s and 1990s, they engaged in a creative cat-and- mouse game with the state to create thriving black markets for alternative media, particularly for video—by means of a mushrooming video club scene—and satellite television—by means of clandestine receivers at home and Persian extraterritorial satellite stations (Naficy 2012a, pp. 339–348). However, they did not stop there. In the 2000s, Iranians developed a third front in the struggle to create an alternative citizen-driven public medium. This was emblematized by the emergence of the internet cinema with which Iranians worldwide challenged the Islamic regime's broadcasting monopoly and mono-vocalism during the presidency of Mahmoud Ahmadinejad, particularly after his disputed re-election (Naficy 2012b, pp. 348–362).

This was a new, legitimate, artistic, and expressive form, regardless of its political uses. Iranian cosmopolitanism, the financial wealth of the country, and the widespread penetration of the internet and its various modalities of connectivity and interactivity drove the emergence of the internet cinema. In 2005, CIA officers at the Open Source Center trolling the internet discovered that Persian/Farsi was among the top five languages in the blogosphere, offering valuable textual and audiovisual information and insight about Iranian people and their sentiments (Shane 2005). In 2008, a Harvard University study further showed that the Persian blogosphere is 'a large discussion space of approximately 60,000 routinely updated blogs featuring a rich and varied mix of bloggers' that ranges from President Mahmoud Ahmadinejad to students (Kelly and Etling 2008, p. 2). Still later studies showed that Iran has 'the most internet users in the Middle East, approaching 30 million' and that Persian is reported as the 'fourth most popular Blogging language on the Internet' (Shahab and Mousoli 2010).

However, as Sreberny and Khiabany rightly note, these figures are ambiguous, as it is not clear how the number of bloggers is calculated and what constitutes an Iranian blog. If the physical location of bloggers is the criteria (counting only those inside Iran), the calculation would ignore the large number of bloggers in the diaspora; if the language of blogging is considered (Persian/Farsi), then all those Iranians, dual national Iranians, and non-Iranians who write in other languages are ignored (2010, pp. 35–36). However they are counted, Iranian bloggers formed a formidable presence in the blogosphere in particular and in cyberspace in general. Because of this presence and because of the strangling of other forms of journalism, the internet became a vital source of information and activism in the 2000s for all sides and a highly contested public diplomacy sphere. The 25-minute film *Iran: The Cyber-Dissidents* (2006), produced by Vivien Altman and reported by Mark Corcoran for Australian Broadcasting Corporation, deals with this burgeoning phenomenon.

What I call 'internet cinema' [1] consists of the totality of the digital media connected by the internet—blogs, films, social networks, and the sharing and streaming of videos—which have turned the internet's virtual space into a vast online public sphere that, in turn, encourages discursive formations and political activism in society, such as the Green Movement, which demand government accountability and democracy. The internet thus became social, not only in its virtuality but also in its actuality. The streets, in turn, became virtual, both in their powerful representations on the internet and in their power to represent. This movement posed the biggest challenge in the lifespan of the Islamic Republic of Iran, not only to its legitimacy but also temporarily to its existence.

Mainstream Western media and exiled Iranian media lauded the power of this new virtual and discursive space ad infinitum, which prematurely and erroneously dubbed the new protests a 'Twitter Revolution', ignoring the fact that technology and media by themselves do not make a revolution (Acuff 2010). In fact, Twitter played a relatively small role at the time inside Iran, partly because of government censorship, but it proved more effective outside the country in publicizing the events (Esfandiari 2010). While Twitter and Facebook were used admirably to exchange information, file news reports and images, and organize protests domestically and internationally (Hashem and Najjar 2010), the social space and the physical place remained high on the agenda of the protesters, emblematized by a street placard carrying the following slogan, addressed to the regime: 'We'll give you back the web sites and mobile phones, but we won't give you the country' (*'Seit O' mobeil arzunitun, keshvar nemidim behetun'*), referring, on the one hand, to the power of the government to shut down the internet and mobile phones and, on the other hand, to the power of citizens to withhold support and to fight back.

The negative consequences of the shift in US and Iranian public diplomacies, from gathering secret information from enemy countries through espionage to collecting information from public sources in those countries, such as through the internet, for mobilizing soft power, was that it politicized, even militarized, all public spheres, including the streets and the internet. Both the people and the government in Iran became camera-shy in public places in major cities. If someone took out a camera to take a picture in the streets, both government agents and passers-by harassed the person—one fearing that the image would be uploaded to social networking sites or to oppositional sites, feeding the gathering anti-regime dissent; the other fearing government surveillance and future arrests. As a result, some of the early protest videos were filmed almost clandestinely, from private places like balconies and from inside apartments and offices, where the filmers were not exposed. Nevertheless, the government attempted to remove, impede, or block these public sources of information and to surveil, track down, imprison, and severely punish the internet operators and users it considered to be aiding the dissidents. Ironically, the US sanctions against the Islamic Republic of Iran, too, initially contributed to the suppression of the digital uprising of Iranians. Although the sanctions law, dating from the Clinton presidency, prohibited Americans from exporting goods and services to Iran, it allowed certain exceptions, among them 'information and informational materials' (Parsi, Elliot, and Disney 2010, p. 164). The problem was that internet technology, or any technology developed in the 1990s, was apparently not covered under this exception,

[1] This chapter is a modified version of a section from Nafcy 2012a, pp. 348–362.

with the result that companies such as Microsoft and Google denied their instant messaging to Iranians (MSN Messenger and Google Talk) because these depended on user downloads, which were interpreted as constituting not information but prohibited service. Even Twitter's legal status came under question until the Obama administration removed the doubt, when in the aftermath of the 2009 elections, it asked Twitter to 'forego routine maintenance in order to continue providing uninterrupted service to Iranians' (Parsi, Elliot, and Disney 2010, p. 165). Six months later, the Iranian Digital Empowerment Act, spearheaded by Representative Jim Moran, which 'authorized downloads of free mass market software by companies such as Microsoft and Google to Iran necessary for exchange of personal communications and/or sharing of information over the internet such as instant messaging, chat and email, and social networking' (Parsi, Elliot, and Disney 2010, p. 166), was passed by the US Congress.

The regime's impediments and censorship efforts did not deter the opposition, either; instead, it encouraged a creative but sometimes deadly and violent game of cat and mouse—both on the internet and in the streets. Protesters found ever more ingenuous alternatives to stay in touch, reconnect, and coordinate actions, and they sought new strategies, internal and international, to create an alternative non-governmental mediascape to publicize their own activities and grievances, organize their protests, and pressure and punish the regime. Many resorted to proxies, which redirected them to banned sites, or used anonymizers, which concealed the identities of senders and recipients. Foremost among these anti-censorship software tools were Tor, Psiphon, Mixminion, Incognito, Freegate, and the purportedly more ingenuous programme Haystack, designed especially for Iran by American hacktivist Austin Heap (Dobson 2010). Many, too, took to the streets to agitate and to record events. One placard in a street demonstration around the time of the disputed 2009 election carried the pithy slogan, 'My [mobile] phone, my medium' ('*Telefon-e man, resaneh-ye man*'), which summarized the defiance of the protesters against the state and its centralized 'big' media, the broadcast media. Amplifying that message, another said 'Every Iranian, a historiographer' ('*Har Irani tarikhnegar*'). A cartoon echoed these sentiments by depicting an Iranian woman wearing a crown of light and posing like the US Statue of Liberty, but instead of holding a lit torch, she holds up a mobile phone emanating waves.

This was the moment for the efflorescence of a new 'little medium', the internet cinema, with its simple, ubiquitous equipment—a mobile phone or a consumer model digital camera or recorder—to replace the formerly powerful little medium of analogue audio cassette, which Ayatollah Khomeini had employed so effectively to energize the Islamic Revolution in the late 1970s (Naficy 2011). This was a new era, necessitating a new medium, for a new cause. Indeed, each protester became a digital medium and a historiographer by taking to the streets, digital camera, mobile phone, or recorder in hand, defying the government's threats of force and terror and its monopoly on the big media. Oppositional film-making against the Islamic Republic of Iran took varied forms: documentaries, fiction films, agitprop films, animated films, internet films, and music videos. Here, I discuss the latter two.

## *Production, Distribution, Exhibition, Reception*

Emboldened by their initial successes in publicizing the protests, internet cinema filmers began to record their videos from the turmoil in the streets, at ground level, instead of from

the safety of the high-rise buildings and from behind windows and curtains as before. With this shift from the private to the public space, and from a distant view to a close-up view of the subjects, came other fundamental political and aesthetic changes in what was recorded. Social barriers and divisions, such as those separating genders, crumbled. Women therefore became such a strong and defiant presence both in the streets and on internet cinema's community videos. Hamed Yusefi's 25-minute film, *The Aesthetics of Political Protest in Iran* (*Zibashenasi-ye E'terazat-e Siasi dar Iran*), aired by BBC Persian on 22 July 2010, provides insightful analysis of these points.

In addition, instead of recording from the point of view of an outsider observing news events, community videographers began to record from the point of view of insiders, engaged in action. Their recording mode thus shifted from direct cinema's fly-on-the-wall observational filming of outside events to cinéma-vérité's provocation-cum-recording of pro-filmic events (Nichols 2001). As such, theirs was not a simple recording of protests that someone else had organized, but an embodied form of protest in whose organization they themselves participated, with all the subjectivity, ambiguity, and hapticity—roughness, shakiness, and out of focus and chaotic aiming and muffled sounds—that these entailed. The result was unedited raw footage of affect, not edited films of a polished presentation. These proved to be very powerful when uploaded onto the video sharing and social networking sites, bypassing government control and censorship.

Unlike traditional films, which are highly planned affairs and involve industrial procedures, high-tech equipment, and numerous skilled personnel both in front and behind the camera, led by a hierarchical command structure, internet films are often a result of individual amateur filmers from around the world sharing their spontaneously shot scenes on video sharing and social media sites. These unplanned scenes become films not by the action of these filmers, but by the actions of others who may utilize the scenes filmed by disparate and unrelated filmers in constructing other longer films of their own or by the actions of the viewers as they surf the net, visiting this or that social media platform. If the first kind of film is a material, 'produced' film consisting of scenes contributed by multiple filmers, the second kind of film is an immaterial 'received' film created by each viewer in the act of receiving or spectating multiple unrelated film scenes. The result is not a single, authoritative film in either case, as each film is the result of the actions of one person, which, at least in the case of the received film, will be entirely individual, personal, immaterial, and immanent to the spectating subject.

However, the affective power of these internet films is often diluted when Western television channels broadcast them, for they often suppress the original Persian language soundtrack, replacing it with their own reporters' voice-over narrations or commentaries. To be sure, the video of Neda Agha-Soltan's on-camera death as broadcast by Western news media was very powerful, but this power came from its tragic content, timing, brief length (40 seconds), and the favourable semiotics of Agha-Soltan's youth, beauty, fair skin, and Westernized veil and attire, which made her a subject with whom Westerners could easily identify (Sabety 2010; Afshar 2010). Its power also came from the video's powerful visuality, the way it clearly witnessed the last eye contact of the dying young woman with the camera, as life departed from her body. However, if viewers saw the original raw footage of her on the internet, without the foreign reporters' voice-over intervention, they would hear the voices of the bystanders—all male—gathered around her trying to console her, communicate with each other, and save

her, as their voices rise into desperate cries, making the video much more compelling in its emotional and visceral impact. Here is my transcription of the bystanders' utterances, some of which are not sufficiently audible:

- 'Let's get someone to carry her away…' [to a hospital?]
- 'Neda! Watch her eyes, watch her eyes.'
- 'Her eyes are turning in.'
- 'Neda, don't be afraid, don't be afraid.'
- 'Oh, oh, oh, OH!' [voices rise to desperate shouts]
- 'Press on her, press on her.' [hands press on her chest, presumably the site of her gunshot wound]
- 'Neda, stay, stay, stay, STAY!' [man's voice rises to a frantic and horrifying shout]
- 'Open her mouth, open her mouth.'[2]

This sort of affective internet cinema augured not only entirely new relations with its social subjects, such as Neda as described above, but also new relations of production, distribution, exhibition, and reception with its viewers. While the site of production of the internet cinema in its initial phases was primarily public places—either in the streets or underground—the site of reception was chiefly private places—homes and other private or semi-private locations. Production—filming—was ad hoc, spontaneous, amateurish, and without official permission, bypassing the strict government approval and censorship apparatuses for public filming. As such, internet cinema is inherently an unauthorized, underground cinema. Its technology of recording is no longer optical and chemical, involving celuloid film or videotape, but is entirely electronic and digital. This technological shift facilitates the globalized production, distribution, and reception of the internet cinema videos.

The production of this cinema occurred in two distinct phases. In the first phase, people with digital cameras recorded the events without editing and uploaded them to internet sites, hence my designation of these practitioners as filmers or videographers, not film-makers. In the case of Agha-Soltan's video, an anonymous person recorded the incident on a mobile phone. In a growing practice, a second phase evolved, during which others, who were not necessarily involved in the first phase, compiled, aggregated, repurposed, edited, and uploaded these internet videos to create other fictional or non- fictional videos. This secondary phase turns multiple individual scenes recorded by disparate filmers into a single film.

Distribution of internet cinema videos is simultaneously both individualized and globalized. The digitized recording of events and their uploading onto social networking, video sharing, and video streaming sites as well as their publication by global news media outlets facilitates this globalized individuality or individualized globalization. In this way, ordinary videographers become not only extraordinary producers but also extraordinary distributors, who bypass the traditional commercial or governmental distribution systems with their complicated monopolistic techno-political economies. In the case of Agha-Soltan's video, the anonymous filmer forwarded the video to the British newspaper *The Guardian*, the network Voice of America, and five other individuals. Significantly, according to *The Guardian*,

[2] To see the video, go to: *Neda Agha-Soltan Shot in Iran*, http://www.dailymotion.com/video/x9oltq_neda-agha-soltan-shot-in-iran_news.

one of these latter individuals—not the filmer—uploaded the video onto Facebook, showing the two-step production of internet films. From that one posting, copies spread to YouTube and were broadcast within hours by CNN. This video was then used in, or served to inspire, numerous types of internet films—fiction, documentary, music video, and animated films. It is thus that this single video went viral and became simultaneously an icon, index, and symbol of the post-election protest and of the democratic aspirations of Iranians—the Green Movement—fulfilling all three definitions of the sign in Charles Sanders Peirce's semiology.

The exhibition venue of the internet cinema vastly differed from other forms of cinema. It shifted from the stationary brick-and-mortar cinemas where people watch films collectively according to a schedule, to small and mobile handheld devices, on which individuals with internet access can watch films at any time, anywhere in the world. This meant that internet cinema's exhibition was freed from both physical location and physical structure, becoming global and virtual. In short, in all its phases of production, distribution, exhibition, and reception, internet cinema moved from professional and formal to amateur and personal forms, marking the ultimate triumph of modernity's individuality in Iranian cinematic expression.

Because of their highly individualized production; their spontaneous, embodied, and amateur aesthetics; their small-scale, short length, and unedited raw footage; and their mobility, first-phase internet videos cannot satisfactorily be labelled as cinema. However, I am applying that term to them because they are a new form of audiovisual expression on their own, and they spawn, in their second phase, other longer, more robust, and professional works, which are exhibited both on the internet and in the cinemas. The internet cinema thus added another type to the typology of cinemas that emerged in the Islamic Republic of Iran. Whatever the most accurate terminology, the fact remains that instead of being dismissed by the world on the grounds of their amateur, improvised aesthetics and brief bursts of raw footage of affect, internet videos gained an added value precisely because of those characteristics of imperfection, which were reminiscent of the Third Cinema's aesthetics of gritty imperfection that in the 1960s and 1970s, had countered both the reigning oppressive political regimes in the world and mainstream cinema's oppressive aesthetic regime of polish and perfection. In fact, the aesthetics of imperfection, smallness, and embodiment of these videos authenticated them fully, as intimate and defiant documents of their filmers' presence on the ground, documenting, provoking, and protesting against a seemingly hegemonic and intractable state and its media.

International recognition of Iranian internet cinema of protest was swift, not only in the reiteration and transmedial dissemination of its videos but also in the awards received from film festivals and media and journalism associations—another reason to call them internet cinema. For example, in 2009 Long Island University bestowed its prestigious journalism award, the George Polk Award for Videography, to the video of Neda Agha-Soltan in recognition of 'the efforts of the people responsible for recording the death of 26-year-old Neda Agha-Soltan at a June protest in Tehran, Iran, and uploading the video to the Internet'.[3]

Internet films, such as Agha-Soltan's video, soon became the contents of other protest films and videos made in different forms—fiction, documentary, animated, and music videos—and some were used, reused, remade, remixed, homaged, signified upon, and repurposed so many

[3] See: https://liu.edu/polk-awards/past-winners#2009

times and so transmedially and rhizomatically in a meandering global chain reaction that they became viral and infectious, even though virality has usually been associated with comedy (Gurney 2011).[4] One of these is *The Green Wave* (2010), which premiered internationally at the International Documentary Film Festival Amsterdam in 2011. Directed by Iranian-born German film- maker Ali Samadi Ahadi, the film, according to its press book, is a 'touching documentary-collage' that illustrates the dramatic 2009 presidential election protests and expresses the feelings of the people involved in the Green Movement. Emblematic of internet cinema,

> Facebook reports, Twitter messages and videos posted in the internet are included in the film composition, and hundreds of real blog entries serve as reference for the experiences and thoughts of two young students, whose story is running through the film as the main thread. The film describes their initial hope and curiosity, their desperate fear, and the courage to yet continue to fight.[5]

These fictional storylines were animated using motion comic technique, and augmented by interviews with prominent human rights campaigners and exiled Iranians, such as Shirin Ebadi, Mohsen Kadivar, Payam Akhavan, Mehdi Mohseni, and Mitra Khalatbari.

These extended internet cinema films, too, received international praise and prizes. For example, in November 2010 the International Documentary Film Festival Amsterdam recognized the importance of these internet films when it gave its Unlimited Award to *The Silent Majority Speaks* (2010) by The Silent Collective, a 93-minute film anthology consisting of fourteen films made on mobile phones and similar devices by anonymous Iranians about the post-election protests and the state violence against protestors. The 5000-euro cash award given to the film was an initiative of Hivos Cultural Fund, one of the NGOs that the Iranian intelligence ministry had identified as supporting a velvet revolution against the regime. The award was given to an Iranian women's rights activist, Mahboubeh Abbasgholizade, condemned in absentia in Iran to two-and-a-half years of prison and 30 lashes, who dedicated her film to the anonymous citizen filmers.[6] In addition, in November 2010, the Foreign Press Association named Iranian journalist Saeed Kamali Dehghan, who regularly writes for *The Guardian*, 'journalist of the year' for his coverage of the disputed presidential election and gave the top award for best TV Feature/Documentary film to the HBO film *For Neda*, which Anthony Thomas had co-directed with Kamali Dehghan (Batty 2010). All these are examples of the internet cinema in its various modalities.

## *Hailing/Counterhailing*

Music videos became one of the most powerful forms of the internet cinema, driven by the global popularity of the music video form, the emergence of dynamic Iranian rock music groups inside Iran and in the diaspora, and the continuing disenchantment of Iranians with their regime. These music videos became effective means of counterhailing the state and its repressive apparatuses. Blurred Vision, a Toronto-based rock band formed in 2007 by brothers

[4] *Neda*, an animated version, offers a historical background of the incident: http://www. youtube.com/watch?v=wXN_yCSbUYk&feature=related.

[5] *The Green Wave* press book: http://www.thegreenwave-film.com.

[6] 'Jayezeh-ye Sinemai Bara-ye "Filmsazan-e Nashenas-e" Iran', http://zamaaneh.com/news/2010/11/post_14948.html.

Sepp and Sohl, who fled Iran with their family in 1986 (and do not reveal their last name to safeguard family members' security in Iran), produced one of the more powerful music videos supporting the protesters of Ahmadinejad's re-election. This video became very popular if not viral. On 30 January 2010, the band remade the famous Pink Floyd song 'Another Brick in the Wall', popular in Iran, into a clear-eyed new protest anthem, 'Another Brick in the Wall (Hey, Ayatollah, Leave Those Kids Alone!)'. In it, they intercut footage of their purported clandestine performance of the song inside Iran, filmed by a fan on a mobile phone, with those of street clashes filmed by anonymous filmers, and an overbearing Ayatollah character who orders the security police to shut down the performance. Within a short time, the music video had been played an impressive 383,394 times on YouTube; however, the brothers were more impressed by the responses from inside Iran.[7] Sepp explained:

> We get a lot of emails, especially from the younger guys, and I remember we were in London for a film festival where we were there to receive an award for best video and Sohl was translating an email into English. And as he was translating he started crying. The email said, 'It is you guys out there that can keep this going for us, that can keep our voice alive. We're here sort of isolated from the rest of the world, we've been shut down and shut off from the rest of the world and all we can say is just keep our voice alive, keep going to allow us to reach this point of freedom. (quoted in Macedo 2010)

That YouTube was often shut down by the Islamic government made such a response all the more significant, since users had to go through extra steps to get around censorship (without censorship, the hits the video received would have been much higher). Not all the comments were positive, however, as some people accused the band of being involved in American soft-power public diplomacy against Iran, of being 'backed by the CIA and the Pentagon and making a fortune off the U.S. government', a charge the band denied, stating that it donates most of the song's download proceeds to Amnesty International. 'It's an ethos of the band that awareness can change the world and music is our tool and platform to do that,' said Sepp, 'and in my opinion it's truly working because the dialogue has begun.' (quoted in Macedo 2010)

'Hey Executioner, Get Lost!' (*'Hey Jallad, Gom Kon Gureto!'*) (2011) is another music video on the protest movement that tapped into Pink Floyd's 'Another Brick in the Wall' song and quoted a line from Blurred Vision's music video version of it, except 'Hey Executioner' is more incendiary than its predecessor. It identifies President Ahmadinejad and Supreme Leader Khamenei as the executioners in its title, urging them to leave a country that is no longer theirs. The video clips of the street demonstrations that accompany the lyrics include images of orderly protests, which are disrupted by police violence, causing the angry demonstrators to turn on the uniformed and plain-clothes police officers, whom they beat up mercilessly and whose van they turn over. The video's message is no longer protest but revolt, summarized in the lyrics, 'We are full of anger, like the typhoon/ We are engaged in a relentless battle/ Listen to me my enemy, there is no place for you in my homeland/ Hey executioner, get lost'.[8]

Yet another effective counterhailing song, which spawned music videos on YouTube, was 'Thorn and Riffraff' (*'Khas O' Khashak'*), which Iranians produced to counter what Ahmadinejad had once labelled the thousands of demonstrators to his re-election, as 'a few thorns and

[7] Blurred Vision's *Another Brick in the Wall*'s music video is at: http://www.dailymotion.com/ video/xcp5ua_blurred-vision-another-brick-in-the_music.

[8] *Hey Executioner, Get Lost* music video is at: http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=wR77TN1_d8k&feature=player_embedded#at=60.

riffraff'. The song turns Ahmadinejad's own words against him and his regime, addressing them in its refrain: You are the thorn and riffraff/ You are lower than dirt/ I am the aching lover/ Ablaze, bright, and full of fervor. [9]

Clearly, these music videos and many others like them, which incorporate internet cinema footage, are examples of citizens withdrawing their support from the regime, and they constitute one of the most effective peaceful means of combatting intolerant and undemocratic regimes. However, these videos took one step further from those that did not feature music video footage. All of them reversed the interpellation that Althusser describes in his famous illustration of a police officer calling a citizen: 'Hey! You, there' (Althusser and Balibar 1971). By turning to respond to the police officer call in that example, the passer-by is hailed and becomes a subject of the state. Instead of being hailed by the state and its agents ('Hey! You, there'), in these videos it is the protesters and their global sympathizers and collaborators who counterhail the state, not only in the video's titles but also in their frequent shouted refrains addressed to the regime: 'Hey, Ayatollah, Leave Those Kids Alone!', 'Hey Executioner, Get Lost!', and 'You are the thorn and riffraff / You are lower than dirt'. It is in this power not only to withdraw consent but also to counterhail the state, of speaking truth to power, that internet cinema finds its political fulfilment.

The Iranian government moved to stifle this new form of cinema, both in its production and dissemination. It began arresting virtual and social activists and videographers, and it arrested an increasing number of bloggers, whose labour complemented the internet cinema, sentencing them to jail terms ranging from a few months to many years. In 2004 it arrested some 20 bloggers and internet journalists (Tehrani 2008), and between 2000 and 2006 Iran became the top censor of the internet in the Middle East (El Gody 2007, p. 223), thwarting the democratic potential of the internet as well as of Iranians. Within a few years, Reporters Without Borders was able to label the Islamic Republic of Iran, along with thirteen other countries, as 'enemies of the Internet' (Shahab and Mousoli 2010). In September 2008, prominent Iranian Canadian blogger, Hosain Derakhshan (nicknamed blogfather, aka Hoder.com), was arrested inside Iran on a variety of charges, among them, collaborating with hostile foreign powers, including Israel. Derakhshan had been the editor of the Internet and Film section of *Doniya-ye Tasvir* (*World of Pictures*) magazine in Tehran and after emigrating to Canada, had introduced 'a simple but groundbreaking' way to show Persian letters and characters on the internet, which contributed to the prominence of Iranians in the blogosphere. This charge of spying was apparently due to a well-publicized trip of his in 2006 to Israel (on his Canadian passport) whose aims were to show 'his 20,000 daily Iranian readers what Israel really looks like and how people live there', and to 'humanize' Iranians for Israelis (Theodoulou 2008). A controversial figure among the blogging community, he had toned down his anti-regime blogging and began supporting it, and he returned to Iran from his self-imposed exile, hoping to work inside the country. He was jailed for nearly two years before finally being sentenced to an incredible nineteen and a half years of imprisonment on charges of 'conspiring with hostile governments, spreading propaganda against the Islamic system, spreading propaganda in favour of counterrevolutionary groups, blasphemy, and creating and managing obscene Web sites' (Mackey 2010).

[9] For *Khas o Khashak*, go to: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=xtLp2VMYF5o.

'Like journalists, bloggers have been treated for months as if they are enemies of the regime', Reporters Without Borders said. 'But the authorities have now started to impose much harsher sentences on them. Bloggers involved in censorship circumvention are being particularly targeted as they help their fellow citizens to gain access to banned information.'[10] Internet censorship took many forms, not only imprisonment but also more subtle and structural forms, such as censorship laws and regulations, content filtering, tapping and surveillance, infrastructural control, telecom control, and self-censorship (El Gody 2007, p. 231). Imprisonment, however, remained a common form of censorship. The Committee to Protect Journalists reported that by February 2010, there were 52 journalists in Iranian jails, a record high that accounted for a third of all the journalists imprisoned in the world.[11] A month later, Reporters Without Borders noted that

> with some sixty journalists and bloggers behind bars and another 50 forced to seek asylum elsewhere, the Islamic Republic of Iran has become the largest prison in the Middle East—and one of the world's largest prisons—for journalists and netizens.[12]

Undeterred, some Iranian activists came up with another tactic: they took legal action against the Islamic Republic's interests from outside Iran. In August 2010, jailed and tortured prominent journalist Isa Saharkhiz and his son, Mehdi Saharkhiz, filed a lawsuit in the US Federal Court in Alexandria, Virginia, against Nokia Siemens Networks and its parent companies, Siemens AG and Nokia Inc., alleging their complicity in the Iranian government's human rights violations through the spying centres that the companies had supplied. The journalist claimed that such centres had conducted surveillance, eavesdropping, and tracking of his mobile phone and other communications after the 2009 elections, resulting in his incarceration and torture. The plaintiffs demanded that Nokia Siemens Networks cease its support of the Iranian intercepting centres and use its connections within the Iranian regime to secure Saharkhiz's freedom. They also called on the United States's judicial system to hold accountable business practices such as the ones engaged in by Nokia Siemens Networks in Iran.[13]

In another tactic, International Campaign for Human Rights in Iran called for the removal of Ezzatollah Zarghami, Director General of Voice and Vision of the Islamic Republic (VVIR, aka IRIB, Islamic Republic of Iran Broadcasting), the state's national broadcast monopoly, on the charge that in addition to its close cooperation with intelligence agents and interrogators, the VVIR, under Zarghami's direction, had 'systematically produced and broadcast programs aimed to target well-known personalities through attributing undue, libellous, and untrue matters to them' (Zarghami 2010). This was a reference to the latest iteration of *Identity* and *Armageddon* shows, a new series called *Sedition Documents* that purported to offer documentaries about reformists such as Ataollah Mohajerani, Abdolkarim Sorush, Akbar Ganji, Shirin Ebadi, Fatemeh Haqiqatju, and Mohsen Sazegara, many in diaspora, aired on main VVIR channels during prime time. Having no access to them to interrogate and force them into incriminating show trials, these state-sanctioned documentaries smeared these individuals by digging up dirt in their private lives and by falsely presenting them as immoral and hostile to Islam

[10] https://rsf.org/en/news/one-blogger-freed-bail-another-blogger-denied-parole.

[11] http://cpj.org/2010/03/with-52-journalists-in-jail-iran-hits-new-shamefu.php.

[12] http://en.rsf.org/spip.php?page=article&id_article=36684.

[13] See: http://onlymehdi.posterous.com/tortured-prominent-iranian-journalist-sues-no.

and to religion (Siamand 2010). The campaign further demanded that the Iranian parliament and judiciary launch an independent inquiry into VVIR's violations of the constitution and citizens' rights on behalf of the defamed individuals who could not defend themselves in the court of public opinion because of the government monopoly of all broadcast media.[14] Assessing the success or failure of these extraterritorial legal interventions in impeding Iranian government's illegal attacks on its own citizens requires further research.

## *Public Diplomacy and Soft-Power Politics*

The Iranian regime took a page from the US government's soft-power public diplomacy rule book, went global, and began countering the US government's funding of anti-Islamic Republic and pro-democracy NGOs inside and outside Iran. This included supporting and funding NGOs in the West that engaged in cultural programming that favoured the Islamic Republic.[15] It also began a wide-ranging 'campaign of harassing and intimidating members of its diaspora worldwide—not just prominent dissidents—who criticize the regime' (Bandow 2009). This unprecedented action consisted not only of slowing down the internet speed, blocking social networking sites (Facebook, Twitter), video-sharing sites (YouTube), internet telephone services (Skype), and cutting email service inside Iran, but also of tracking the activities of Iranians on networking sites worldwide, creating fake sites for the protesters to rope in more victims, monitoring Iranian protesters in diaspora (900 were tracked in Germany), videotaping their public demonstrations in order to harass them and their families at home, and sending them anonymous threatening emails to cease and desist from 'spreading lies and insults' (Fassihi 2009). All these measures may have been facilitated and enhanced by the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps' takeover of the telecom infrastructure.

It must be noted that the situation governing the internet in Iran is very complicated and conflictual not only within the opposing factions—pro- and anti-government—but also within each faction. For example, within the ruling faction, one faction bans Twitter while others turn to it as their favourite medium of communication with their cadres and to the nation. On 15 August 2018, Mohammad Jafar Montazeri, the attorney general, condemned the actions of some of the lawmakers to lift the ban on Twitter, calling it a 'highway to corruption' whose control is in the hands of 'the enemy'. His deputy accused Twitter of having had a major hand in the 'seditious' Green Movement, which led to its banning soon thereafter. Despite that ban, not only ordinary citizens and social activists but also high-ranking officials such as Abbas Ali Kadkhodai, the spokesperson for the Guardian Council, and even the supreme leader himself, Ali Khamenei, maintain their Twitter accounts and actively communicate

[14] 'Iranian State TV Acts as an Arm of the Intelligence Apparatus', http://www.iranhumanrights.org/2010/08/iranian-state-tv-acts-as-an-arm-of-the-intelligence-apparatus/print/.

[15] One NGO that purportedly received such help was the Center for Iranian Studies in Toronto; see: 'Is Toronto Cultural Centre Funded by Iran's Mullah Regime?', http://www.onlydemocracy4iran.com/2010/04/15/is-toronto-cultural-centre-funded-by-irans-mullah-regime/. National Iranian American Council (NIAC) has also been accused of promoting Islamic Republic causes by some exiles, even though it has received funding from the US government and other American foundations, which would militate against such cross-funding. NIAC denies any affiliations with the Iranian regime. See: 'EDITORIAL: Voice of the mullahs: Public diplomacy takes a pro-Islamist tilt', http://www.washingtontimes.com/news/2010/apr/14/voice-of-the-mullahs/; http://english.iranianlobby.com/page1.php?id=22&bakhsh=JOURNAL; http://www.niacouncil. org/site/PageServer?pagename=About_myths_facts.

with them.[16] Kadkhodai went as far as to state that he does not consider using Twitter to be illegal.[17] The cat-and-mouse game around social media continues at all levels and in all sectors of society.

In 2010, Ahmadinejad's government attempted another tactic: it put on another charm offensive for the Iranians in diaspora who had previously been denigrated by the Islamic Republic leaders. It established the High Council of Iranians Abroad, which sought to attract thousands of professional Iranians and potential investors to visit, invest in, and return to Iran. It also sought to facilitate their travels by establishing a 24-hour hotline, establishing branch offices of the council in Iranian provinces, supporting the creation of 'Iran House' branches in foreign countries, and organizing in Tehran a massive Grand Conference of Iranians Living Abroad, offering to pay for participants' travel and accommodations.[18] However, instead of 'polishing Iran's image', the grand conference, 'ended up showcasing many of the country's bitter internal divisions' (Yong and Worth 2010), and the opposition was quick to post the participants' names and pictures on the internet in an effort to 'expose the double crossers'.[19]

Such politicization of digital media and the internet by the public diplomacy quartet of partners—Western powers, the Iranian regime, Iranian dissidents at home, and Iranian dissidents in diaspora—had the unfortunate result of deeply and structurally politicizing the Iranian domestic and diaspora media and internet cinema, whether their contents were political or not, degrading their professional impartiality and journalistic fairness, and undermining the media and civil society formations inside and outside the country, regardless of whether they had accepted American or Iranian governments funding or not, feeding Iranians' penchant for conspiracy thinking. It also made Iranian or binational Iranian intellectuals, academics, artists, bloggers, filmers, film-makers, and community activists, whether they were beneficiaries of public diplomacy funding or not, suspect to the Iranian and Western intelligence services or targets of their surveillance and recruitment, with serious consequences for their democratic aspirations and their lives.

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[16] See: 'Dadsetan-e Koll-e Iran: Telegram va Instagram Bala Ijad Kardehand', https://m.dw.com/fa-ir/iran/a-45090089?maca=fa-IR-Whatsapp-sharing&.

[17] See: 'Sokhangu-ye Showra-ye Negahban Estefadeh az Twitter ra Gheir-e Qanuni Nemidanad', http://www.bbc.com/persian/iran-45202575?ocid=wspersian.chat-apps.in-app-msg.whatsapp.trial.link1_.auin.

[18] See: http://congress.iranianshouse.ir/; http://congress.iranianshouse.ir/.

[19] 'Barkhi Sherkat Konandegan-e dar Hamayesh-e Bozorg-e Iranian-e Moqime-e Kharej', http://greenprotests.blogspot.com/2010/08/blog-post_05.html.

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